

Forbidden fruit

I BOUGHT AN IPHONE XS. However, I assure you that I'm not going to be singing empty praises of Apple anytime soon, even if I have officially become an iPhone owner. What prompted this change of heart? The death of the home button on the iPhone (or whatever the fanboys call it). As a lifelong BlackBerry user, I had come to love swipe navigation – swiping up from the bottom of the phone to show open apps, swiping down from the top of the phone to show quick settings, etc. Over the years, Apple and Android have slowly but surely, arrived at the same conclusions about navigation as BlackBerry did, and this is a huge step in the right direction for me. That's not the purpose of this column however.

Recently I've found myself arguing with a lot of Apple users, and the one thing that they keep coming back to is the heroing of privacy by Apple. Tim Cook once said, "...we could make a ton of money if we monetized our customer – if our customer was our product. We've elected not to do that."

I think it's pretty stupid for any one company to mock the successful business model of another company and try and praise their own business model. Some consumers are willing to shell out an arm and a leg for privacy, while some just don't care and want things cheap, or better yet, free.

The tug of war between companies on both these sides is good for us. Free alternatives that are ad-supported define the industry. From paying for email space in MBs we have reached a point where you get GBs of free storage online. The entire concept of the cloud – cloud storage, cloud computing, etc – wouldn't exist if such services hadn't driven costs down.

Apple's model, on the other hand, made the concept of touch interfaces mainstream,

and also the smartphone. They made their comeback as a gadget hardware company, even if they are far more than that now. Heck, Apple made \$1 billion in 2017 just from selling app ads on its own app store. In order to do that, Apple had to track you and your usage, and then create a profile of you, and then show you stuff you might be interested in... sound familiar?

Facebook is supposed to be used in exactly the same way. No advertiser is supposed to have a profile of you and what you like, only Facebook is supposed to. They screwed up by being lax, and not necessarily evil. It's the same way Google works.

In all three cases listed above, the advertiser does not know that this guy called Robert who works at Digit saw his ad, he just knows someone who likes Digit's Facebook page, or visit's digit.in often saw his ad. You can be as precise with the targeting as you want, depending on what data the service collects about you. Google is the most successful at this because it has you hooked in many more ways, using many more services, but Facebook has you for the longest period per day, and perhaps knows you better. Apple is playing catch up here, and believe me, they want to and have to catch up.

While people disagree about whether the collection of private data is evil, we all agree that we want our interface with technology to be a smoother affair. We want to think it and have it done... we want to carry a consciousness in our pocket, and have a truly smart phone... that's not going to come from thumping your chest about privacy, though...

Do you care what Google knows about you? Write in and let me know.



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